

Fully grown big brown bats have wingspans of roughly 13 in (33 cm), and body lengths of up to 5 in (12 cm). Females are slightly larger than males.



See also

Find out about polar bears (124–125), who also survive the winter by hibernating.

Home to roost

By morning, bats have returned to their roosts—in tree hollows, caves, or buildings. As summer turns to fall and days get colder, bats fly less and spend more time in their roosts.

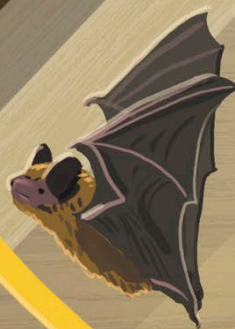
Summer hunting

The bats do most of their flying on warm, dry summer nights—when there are plenty of insects around. Some bats set out in the late afternoon, but most are active two or three hours after sunset. They will keep hunting through the night.



First flight

At three to four weeks old, the pups begin to take short flights. In order to catch flying insects in the dark, they learn a technique called echolocation. It helps bats find their way using sounds.



Vampire bat Vampire bats regurgitate (bring back up) blood they have digested from their prey to feed their pups. They even do this to feed bats from other families.



Echolocation Insect-eating bats use echolocation to find their food and avoid bumping into things at night. The bat calls out and then listens for an echo. If there is an insect or tree in the area, the echo lets the bat know where it is.